

Installing EduHelpdesk

Version 1.6

EduHelpdesk is an IT helpdesk for schools: tickets, a staff portal for reporting problems, an asset register with loans and kits, parts, purchasing projects, reports and an audit log. It runs on one Windows computer in school, and staff reach it in their web browser.

This guide is for whoever looks after IT at the school. Installing takes about ten minutes.

What you need

- **A Windows computer that stays on**, 64-bit: Windows 10 or 11, or Windows Server 2016 or newer. A server is best; a desktop that is never switched off will do.
- **An administrator account** on that computer.
- **About 500 MB of disk** for the program, plus room for the data - a school's database and ticket attachments usually stay well under a few gigabytes.
- **Nothing to download**. Everything it needs, the .NET runtime included, is in the zip.
- **Somewhere for the nightly backups** - ideally another drive or a network share.
- **Optional: a certificate** for HTTPS (see *HTTPS* below). Without one the helpdesk still works, but passwords cross the network unencrypted.

Installing

1. **Unzip the whole zip** to a folder on the computer, for example C:\Install\EduHelpdesk-1.6. Don't run it from inside the zip.
2. **Double-click** `Install.cmd` and say **Yes** when Windows asks for administrator rights. If Windows shows "*Windows protected your PC*", click **More info**, then **Run anyway** - the installer isn't signed with a certificate.
3. **Answer the questions**. Press Enter to take the suggestion in brackets.
4. When it finishes, it shows the **address** of the helpdesk, such as `http://helpdesk-pc/`. Staff use that address.

The questions

Question	Suggested	What it means
Data folder	C:\EduHelpdesk\Data	Where the database, attachments and sign-in keys live. Use a plain local folder on a drive that is backed up. Not OneDrive, Dropbox or similar - sync clients damage live databases, and the installer refuses them. If the folder already holds an EduHelpdesk database, it offers to use it.
School name	EduHelpdesk	Shown in the header, the staff portal and on printouts.
Main colour	#067A78	Buttons and headings, as #RRGGBB. Use your school's colour.
Accent colour	#E8F0EF	A pale shade used behind highlights.
Logo	(none)	The full path to a PNG of the crest or logo, under 2 MB. Can be added later in Settings.
Backup folder	the data folder's backups	Where the nightly backup goes. Another drive or a network share is better: a backup on the same drive doesn't survive that drive failing.

Question	Suggested	What it means
Backup hour	2	The hour (0-23) the backup runs, when nobody is using the helpdesk.
Use HTTPS	yes, if there's a certificate	Only asked when the computer has a certificate. See <i>HTTPS</i> .
Port	80 (443 with HTTPS)	Leave it unless something else on the computer uses that port; the installer suggests another if so. With 80 or 443, staff don't need to type a port.
Open the firewall	yes	Lets other computers on the school network reach the helpdesk.
Public networks too	yes	Only asked if Windows has the computer's network down as Public (common on a network it doesn't recognise), because there it blocks other computers. Better still, make the network Private or join the domain - see <i>Troubleshooting</i> .

Everything the school name, colours, logo and backups questions set can be changed later in **Settings**.

What the installer does

- Copies the program to C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk.
- Registers a Windows service called **EduHelpdesk**. It starts with Windows, restarts itself if it ever stops, and runs under its own limited account, NT SERVICE\EduHelpdesk, which can only change the data folder.
- Opens the port in Windows Firewall for EduHelpdesk (domain and private networks, and public ones if you said so), and removes any rule Windows made earlier to block it.
- Starts the service and checks the site answers.
- Keeps a log of the install in C:\ProgramData\EduHelpdesk.

Signing in the first time

1. Open the address the installer showed.
2. Sign in straight away as **admin@eduhelpdesk.local** with the password **ChangeMe123!**. You'll be asked to choose your own password, and then given a **recovery key**: download the recovery file and keep it safe, because it's how you reset the password if you forget it. > Until you do, anyone on the network who knows this default could sign in first - so do it as soon as the install finishes.
3. The helpdesk starts with a **worked example** - a few tickets, assets and people - so you can see how things fit together. When you're ready, **Settings** → **Go live & reset** → **Remove demo data** clears it.

Then, in Settings

- **Branding & logo**: check the name, colours and logo.
- **Sign-in security**: turn on **two-step sign-in** for your own account (from your account menu), then require it for every staff account. The DfE's cyber security standard expects this.
- **Your recovery key**: keep the file you were given somewhere safe (or make a new one from **Recovery key** in your account menu). If you forget your password, it lets you reset it from the sign-in page. For the built-in administrator, it's the way back in without another administrator.
- **People**: add your technicians (Staff accounts) and give them roles, and import staff who will use the portal (Requesters, from a CSV). Each account you add gets a temporary password and a one-page **quick start guide** to print and hand over; an import prints a guide for everyone in it.

- **Sign-in security** → **Helpdesk address**: check it's the address staff will type. It's printed on every quick start guide.
- **Backups & data**: after the first night, check the backup ran.
- The **Technical Guide** (docs\Technical-Guide.md in the zip) explains every setting, and the **Staff Guide** (docs\Staff-Guide.md) is written for the staff who use the portal.

HTTPS

HTTPS encrypts everything between the browser and the helpdesk, passwords included. It needs a **certificate** for the name staff will type, installed in **Local Computer** → **Personal** on the helpdesk computer, with its private key. Your IT provider, your trust or your local authority can usually issue one from the school's own certificate authority.

- **If the certificate is there before you install**: answer **yes** to HTTPS and pick it from the list. The installer does the rest, including letting the service read the certificate's private key.
- **To add HTTPS later**: install the certificate, then edit C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk\appsettings.Production.json. Change the address to https://*:443, add the certificate, and turn on RequireHttps:

```
{
  "EduHelpdesk": { "DataPath": "C:\\EduHelpdesk\\Data", "RequireHttps": true },
  "Kestrel": { "Endpoints": { "Main": {
    "Url": "https://*:443",
    "Certificate": { "Subject": "helpdesk.school.org.uk", "Store": "My", "Location": "LocalMachine" }
  } } }
}
```

Then, in certlm.msc, right-click the certificate → **All Tasks** → **Manage Private Keys**, add NT SERVICE\EduHelpdesk with **Read**, open port 443 in the firewall, and restart the **EduHelpdesk** service (Services, or Restart-Service EduHelpdesk).

Backups and restoring

A backup is made every night at the hour you chose, and kept for 14 days (change both in **Settings** → **Backups & data**, which also has **Back up now**). Each backup is a zip holding the database, attachments, logo and sign-in keys, plus a RESTORE.txt with step-by-step instructions for putting it back.

A network share needs to let the **computer's own account** write to it - SCHOOL\HELPDESK-PC\$, for a computer called HELPDESK-PC - because that's who the service is on the network.

Updating to a new version

1. Unzip the new version's zip to its own folder.
2. Double-click its Install.cmd.

The installer sees EduHelpdesk is already installed and **upgrades it without asking anything**:

- It stops the service.
- It zips the data into the backups folder, named before-upgrade-<old>-to-<new>.
- It swaps in the new program, keeping your settings and data.
- It starts the service again.

If the new version doesn't start, it puts the previous one back and tells you. The version you're on is in **Settings** → **About EduHelpdesk**.

Installing without questions

For a trust installing at several schools: copy `install-answers.example.json` to `install-answers.json`, fill it in, and run from an administrator command prompt in the unzipped folder:

```
Install.cmd -AnswersFile install-answers.json
```

Answer	Meaning
ProgramFolder	Where the program goes (C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk if left out).
DataFolder	The data folder.
UseExistingData	true to use a database already in that folder.
SchoolName, PrimaryColor, AccentColor, LogoPath	As the questions above.
BackupFolder, BackupHour	As the questions above.
UseHttps, CertificateThumbprint	For HTTPS: the thumbprint of the certificate in Local Computer → Personal.
Port, OpenFirewall	As the questions above.
AllowOnPublicNetwork	true to open the port on Public networks too (only used if the computer is on one).

Anything left out takes the suggested value. A wrong answer stops the install with a message rather than guessing.

Moving to another computer

- **With the old one still running:** make a backup in **Settings** → **Backups & data**. Stop the EduHelpdesk service on the old computer. Copy its data folder to the new computer. Install there, and choose that folder when asked - the installer offers to use the database it finds.
- **Or:** unzip on the new computer and run `Install.cmd -ImportFrom "\\oldpc\c$\EduHelpdesk\Data"` from an administrator command prompt; it copies the data across into the new data folder and leaves the original alone.

Users sign in again afterwards, and everything else carries over.

Uninstalling

Double-click `Uninstall.cmd` (from any copy of the zip). It removes the service, the firewall rule and the program folder. **The data folder is kept** - reinstall and choose it to carry on, or delete it yourself once you are sure. It holds tickets and personal data, so dispose of it as your data protection policy says.

Where things are

What	Where
Program	C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk (the previous version, after an upgrade, in <code>EduHelpdesk.previous</code>)
This install's settings	C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk\appsettings.Production.json
Data	The folder you chose - <code>helpdesk.db</code> , attachments, keys, logs and more

What	Where
Error log	logs in the data folder, and Settings → Error log
Install logs	C:\ProgramData\EduHelpdesk
The service	EduHelpdesk in Services (services.msc)

Troubleshooting

The installer says to run it as administrator. Right-click Install.cmd → **Run as administrator**, or sign in to Windows with an administrator account.

"Something else on this computer is already using port 80." Another web server (often IIS) has it. Choose another port, such as 5277; staff then type it in the address, for example `http://helpdesk-pc:5277/`.

It works on the helpdesk computer but not from others.

- **The network is Public.** Windows files a network it doesn't recognise as *Public* and blocks incoming connections there. Check with `Get-NetConnectionProfile` in PowerShell. Either make it Private (**Settings** → **Network & internet** → the network → **Private**) or join the computer to the domain, or run Install.cmd again: run over an existing install it repairs the firewall and includes Public networks when the computer is on one.
- **The firewall wasn't opened.** Run Install.cmd again, or open the port yourself from an administrator PowerShell (use your port):

```
New-NetFirewallRule -DisplayName "EduHelpdesk (80)" -Direction Inbound -Protocol TCP -LocalPort 80 -Program "C:\Program Files\EduHelpdesk\EduHelpdesk.exe" -Action Allow -Profile Domain,Private,Public
```

- **The name doesn't resolve.** The installer lists the computer's IP addresses at the end - try `http://<address>/` instead.
- Running EduHelpdesk.exe by hand while the service is stopped makes Windows ask to allow it through the firewall. There's no need: the service is what people use, and the installer's rule already covers the program.

The service won't stay running. Look in the data folder's logs, and in **Event Viewer** → **Windows Logs** → **Application** (source EduHelpdesk). A common cause after adding HTTPS is the service not being allowed to read the certificate's private key.

The browser says the certificate isn't trusted, or doesn't match. The certificate must be issued for exactly the name people type, by an authority school computers trust.

The default admin password doesn't work. Someone has already changed it - which is what should happen. If they made a recovery key, **Forgotten your password?** on the sign-in page resets it. Otherwise another administrator can set a new password under **People** → **Staff accounts**.

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